

Ancient empires

In the ancient world, as civilizations grew, some had ambitions to become richer and more powerful by conquering or controlling their neighbors. The most successful conquerors created huge empires.

Rise and fall
This map shows the territories of each ancient empire at its peak. Some empires fell as dramatically as they rose, whereas others, such as the Roman Empire, declined gradually over centuries.



Stone head of Queen Meritaten of the 18th Dynasty of Egypt

New Kingdom of Egypt
1550–1069 BCE
The Egyptian New Kingdom grew under Thutmose III, one of the first great generals in history. At its peak, Egypt ruled the southeast Mediterranean.

Roman Empire in 117 CE

GAUL

Rome

IBERIA

MAURETANIA

GREECE

ASIA MINOR

MESOPOTAMIA

Babylon

First Persian Empire in 490 BCE

Pasargadae

EGYPT

Thebes

New Kingdom of Egypt in 1450 BCE

Empires in retreat

The larger an empire grows, the more complex and expensive it becomes to rule. Roman Emperor Trajan seized Mesopotamia in 117 CE, but his successor Hadrian gave it up almost immediately, believing it not worth the expense.

Civilizations of the Americas

The Olmec and Maya cultures spread, like the empires of Eurasia and Africa, as their communities merged and grew. Trade and cultural exchange, rather than violent conquest, was probably the main way their cultures expanded.

Olmec civilization
c.700 BCE

Mayan civilization
c.300 CE

Area of main map